

Boston College - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bottom-third Power 4 team with a credible improvement path, but too many high-leverage projection bets for a stable bowl-level forecast.
Preseason consensus	unranked (0 votes) · ACC media 16th · No. 82
Returning production	49% (No. 82) overall · Off. 42% (No. 109) · Def. 57% (No. 51)
Primer power rating	-2.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	3.9 wins · most likely 4-8
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ - Modestly better from a 2-10 baseline, but still below-average overall.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Bill O'Brien is rebuilding the offense around QB Mason McKenzie's quick decisions, high-percentage throws, timed deep shots, quarterback-run element and a multi-back rotation, while Ted Roof wants a more disruptive defense built around pressure/turnovers and a veteran secondary.

Bottom line: Boston College should be more coherent than the 2-10 team it replaces, but SP+ No. 82 and No. 109 offensive returning production mean bowl contention requires McKenzie plus the rebuilt OL/front seven to beat their preseason baseline.

Beats expectations if: QB Mason McKenzie translates the streamlined offense, the new OL finds a stable five, and the transfer front creates enough pressure/turnovers for the veteran secondary to matter.

Disappoints if: The OL rebuild leaves QB Mason McKenzie under constant stress, TE Kaelan Chudzinski's absence shrinks the middle, and the transfer-heavy front fails to improve the defense.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Mason McKenzie is the installed/projected starting quarterback, not a 50/50 camp battle, but he remains unproven at Power 4 level.
- 2 ? Defensive availability:** Bill O'Brien will call the offense; Ted Roof is the new DC, but the exact defensive game-day caller remains unresolved.
- 3 ? QB question:** Offensive returning production is only 42% (No. 109), and the departures include QB Dylan Lonergan, RB Turbo Richard, WR Lewis Bond/Reed Harris and multiple starting linemen; TE Kaelan Chudzinski is also likely unavailable.
- 4 ♦ Roster overhaul:** S KP Price is the clearest defensive anchor, while a transfer-heavy front seven is being asked to fix a 2025 defense that ranked No. 122 in EPA allowed and No. 126 in havoc created.
- 5 ? Key uncertainty:** SP+ projects 3.9 wins with SOS No. 27; the late sequence includes road games at Notre Dame and Miami, so BC needs to bank the Rutgers/Pittsburgh/Syracuse tier of games to threaten bowl eligibility.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	2-10 (1-7 ACC)	● Very poor
Scoring	25.4 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	384.1 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	103.9 YPG · 3.3 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	7.41 YPA · 20 TD / 12 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	38.6%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	32.8 PPG allowed	● Very poor
Total defense	433.2 YPG allowed	● Very poor
Rush defense	177.6 YPG · 5.0 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	255.7 YPG · 8.20 YPA · 23 TD allowed	● Very poor

The offense was below average but not uniformly broken: scoring No. 85 and total offense No. 73, with a severe rushing weakness at No. 127. The defense was worse across the board—scoring No. 123, total defense No. 128, rush defense No. 106 and pass-efficiency defense No. 121.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-3.05 · No. 93	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.069 · No. 95	● Below average
Off. success rate	42.6% · No. 67	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	9.6% · No. 128	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 89	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	-4.96 · No. 107	● Poor
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.132 · No. 122	● Very poor
Def. success rate allowed	43.7% · No. 98	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.3% · No. 78	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	12.2% · No. 126	● Very poor

Advanced-stat read: The 2025 offense could sustain some plays (success rate No. 67) but had almost no explosive dimension (No. 128) and finished below average in EPA/opponent-adjusted offense.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Bill O'Brien - returning head coach and confirmed 2026 offensive play-caller	● ↔ O'Brien's return plus confirmed play-calling keeps the offensive chain of command stable.
DC	◆ Ted Roof - new external defensive coordinator	● ↑ Roof introduces a new defensive voice to a unit that needs substantial improvement.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Mason McKenzie	Saginaw Valley State	● ↔ Installed/projected starter and central 2026 variable; system fit is supported.
◆ RB Evan Dickens	Liberty	● ↔ Primary four-back rotation member with Doak Walker recognition.
◆ RB Nolan Ray	Maryland	● ↔ Repeated camp evidence places him in the primary rotation.
◆ WR Javarius Green	North Carolina	● ↔ Projected major receiver/slot role as BC replaces substantial 2025 receiving volume.

Out	To	Loss
QB Dylan Lonergan	Rutgers	● ↔ Nine-game 2025 starting quarterback departs; QB McKenzie is installed as replacement.
RB Turbo Richard	Indiana	● ↓ Primary 2025 back with major rushing/receiving volume departs.
WR Lewis Bond	NFL (Houston), Round 6, No. 204	● ↓ 2025 leading receiver/All-ACC contributor leaves via the 2026 NFL Draft.
WR Reed Harris	Arizona State	● ↓ Twelve-game 2025 starter departs, increasing receiver reconstruction.
OL Eryx Daugherty	Louisville	● ↓ 2025 starting lineman departs by transfer.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Worse continuity and depth certainty, especially at OL/WR/TE, even though the new QB plan could still improve offensive coherence.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL KJ Sampson	Florida State	● ↔ Projected major interior role in a front-seven rebuild.
◆ DE Kris Jones	Georgia	● ↔ Expected primary edge role with camp evidence, but not a proven BC difference-maker yet.
◆ LB Anthony Palano	Washington State	● ↑ Seven prior starts and current camp impact reps support a major linebacker projection.
◆ LB Bodie Kahoun	Notre Dame	● ↔ Likely major linebacker role in a new front-seven mix.

Out	To	Loss
DB Omar Thornton	Miami	● ↓ 2025 starting safety/high-volume tackler departs.
EDGE Edwin Kolenge	Vanderbilt	● ↓ 2025 starting edge contributor departs from a front already needing more disruption.
DL Owen Stoudmire	Nebraska	● ↓ Established starting defensive tackle departs by transfer.
LB Bam Crouch	Kansas	● ↓ Captain/starter-level linebacker departs.
DE Quintayvious Hutchins	NFL (New England), Round 7, No. 247	● ↓ 2025 starting defensive lineman leaves via the 2026 NFL Draft.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Similar overall with a modest upside path from Roof and the transfer front, but too much turnover to call a clear upgrade.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	HC Bill O'Brien tailors quick decisions, timed deep shots and QB-run elements to QB Mason McKenzie.	Four-back depth and WR Jaedn Skeete help the new QB stay on schedule.	Low-continuity OL/TE rooms and No. 128 explosiveness.
Defense	Roof emphasizes stops, turnovers, pressure and negative plays.	S Price, Davis and CB Tucker give the secondary more returning stability than the front seven.	The 2025 defense was poor in EPA/success rate/havoc.
Special teams	Returning kicker with an unsettled punter job.	K Luca Lombardo carries Groza recognition; SP+ ranks the unit No. 28.	Punter remains unsettled.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	QB McKenzie is the installed starter and O'Brien has tailored the offense to him.
RB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	RB Dickens, Ray, MacCormack and Dodd form an explicit four-back group; depth is credible.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Skeete is back and WR Green/Swanson/Pough give the room options.
TE	● C-	● ↓	Low	TE Franklin departs and TE Kaelan Chudzinski is likely unavailable.
OL	● C-	● ↓	Low	Multiple 2025 starting linemen departed by transfer/draft/NFL opportunity.
DL/Edge	● C	● ↔	Medium-low	The 2025 front was ineffective and loses DE Hutchins/EDGE Kolenge/DL Stoudmire/McConnell.
LB	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	LB Palano and LB Kahoun give the staff credible transfer options.
Secondary	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	S KP Price, Carter Davis and CB Max Tucker are established returners.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium	SP+ ranks the unit No. 28.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Medium	O'Brien provides offensive continuity and will call plays; Roof brings coordinator experience.
Overall	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No. 82 fits a below-average Power 4 roster with a credible improvement path.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
KP Price	S	● High-end conference starter / defensive centerpiece	ACC preseason first team	The clearest returning star and the anchor of BC's most stable defensive group.
◆ Mason McKenzie (TR: Saginaw Valley State)	QB	● Unproven Power 4 starter / system-fit projection	-	Official BC reporting treats him as the installed starter.
◆ Evan Dickens (TR: Liberty)	RB	● Projected major rotation back	Doak Walker	Primary four-back rotation member and BC's only recognized RB.
Jaedn Skeete	WR	● Returning major receiver	-	Back from a spring shoulder issue.
◆ Anthony Palano (TR: Washington State)	LB	● Projected major linebacker / solid starter candidate	-	Seven prior starts plus impact camp reps give BC a credible experienced centerpiece.
◆ KJ Sampson (TR: Florida State)	DL	● Projected major interior transfer role	-	Key addition for a front that created little 2025 havoc.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Max Tucker	CB	● Established conference starter	-	First-group corner who helps make the secondary the defense's most stable unit.
Luca Lombardo	K	● Established specialist	Lou Groza	A known kicker on an SP+ top-30 special-teams unit.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Difficult for a rebuilding team; several mid-tier games are competitive in concept, but the late Notre Dame/Miami road tests sharply constrain the ceiling.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · SP+ SOS No. 27
Hardest stretch	Florida State -> at Notre Dame -> Syracuse -> at Miami
Swing games	Rutgers, Pittsburgh, Syracuse
Advantage	Maine, Rutgers and Syracuse are at home, and the Week 6 bye precedes the Pittsburgh/Georgia Tech/Duke stretch.
Expected	3.9 wins; likely 4-8
Floor / ceiling	2-10 / 6-6

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 2-10 record and 16th-place ACC media projection create a naturally discounted profile.
Back them when	Consider BC when catching meaningful points against mid-tier opponents after QB McKenzie and the OL show they can keep the offense on schedule.
Fade/pass when	Pass or lean away against strong pass rushes and efficient offenses until the rebuilt OL and transfer front prove functional.
Key monitor	QB Mason McKenzie Power 4 translation, Final offensive-line five, Kaelan Chudzinski availability and TE replacement usage, Front-seven transfer roles and havoc creation, Exact defensive game-day play-caller, RB carry distribution
Week 1 baseline	Boston College +7.5 at Cincinnati - Boston College primer -2.5 minus Cincinnati final preseason SP+ +3.0 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Live market: Boston College +7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Boston College’s improvement case starts with a cleaner offensive plan for QB Mason McKenzie and a deep RB rotation, while S KP Price leads a veteran secondary. The hard part is supporting those strengths with a rebuilt OL/TE group and transfer-heavy front seven.

The 2025 offense lacked explosives and the defense lacked efficiency and havoc, so coherence alone is not enough. With SOS No. 27 and difficult late road trips, **3.9 wins and 4-8** remains the baseline, with bowl contention requiring several newcomer bets to hit.

About this primer

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